

Quantum Cryptography Key Management Using AES-256: A Classical Simulation Approach with Qiskit and PennyLane

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Abstract—With the emergence of quantum computing, classical cryptographic systems face major risks, especially public-key algorithms like RSA and ECC. Symmetric algorithms like AES, though more resilient, also face reduced security margins under Grover’s algorithm. This paper presents a hybrid framework that combines AES-256 encryption with quantum key distribution (QKD) principles, simulated using classical platforms such as Qiskit and PennyLane in Google Colab. The approach demonstrates secure key management through BB84-inspired key exchange, integration with AES-256 encryption, and performance evaluation under noise. Experimental results highlight the entropy of derived keys, basis match frequencies, and Quantum Bit Error Rate (QBER) resilience. By allowing efficient simulations on classical hardware, this framework connects theoretical quantum cryptography with real-world implementation, ensuring the protection of quantum infrastructures from unauthorized access.

Index Terms—AES-256, key handling, PennyLane, post-quantum security, Qiskit, quantum encryption

I. INTRODUCTION

The rise of quantum computing brings both remarkable opportunities and substantial challenges to the field of cybersecurity. By exploiting quantum phenomena such as superposition and entanglement, quantum computers possess the theoretical potential to solve problems that are practically unsolvable for traditional systems. This technological shift directly threatens the foundational security principles of contemporary cryptographic mechanisms, which depend on the computational difficulty of mathematical problems like integer factorization and discrete logarithms.

Public-key cryptographic algorithms including RSA and ECC are especially at risk. Shor’s algorithm can efficiently factor large integers and compute discrete logarithms in polynomial time, making RSA-2048 and ECC-256 practically obsolete once scalable quantum systems become a reality [7]. Although symmetric encryption methods such as the Advanced Encryption Standard (AES) exhibit greater resistance, they are not completely secure. Grover’s algorithm introduces a quadratic improvement in brute-force key searches, effectively lowering the security level of AES-256 to around 128 bits

[8]. While this remains a strong level of protection, it underscores the pressing necessity for advanced key management techniques and hybrid cryptographic models capable of withstanding quantum-based attacks.

Beyond the threat to cryptographic algorithms, quantum infrastructures themselves represent critical assets requiring protection. Cloud-accessible quantum computers, such as IBM Q, Google Sycamore, and AWS Braket, expose new attack surfaces through remote job submissions, multi-tenant environments, and control-plane vulnerabilities [9]. Maintaining the integrity and confidentiality of quantum workloads demands strong cryptographic solutions that enforce access control and prevent potential misuse.

An effective strategy involves combining Quantum Key Distribution (QKD) with classical cryptographic primitives. Protocols like BB84 utilize the no-cloning theorem and quantum measurement principles to ensure the secrecy of shared keys [2]. Despite their advantages, practical implementation of QKD faces challenges due to its dependence on specialized components such as photon detectors and quantum communication channels, which restrict availability to most researchers and professionals.

Simultaneously, the National Institute of Standards and Technology (NIST) has advanced efforts in Post-Quantum Cryptography (PQC) standardization, resulting in the selection of lattice-based and hash-based schemes, including ML-KEM and Dilithium, for near-term deployment. [1].

This paper argues for a hybrid solution: combining AES-256, which remains computationally efficient and quantum-resilient, with QKD principles simulated in classical environments. By leveraging open-source tools like Qiskit [5] and PennyLane [4], we demonstrate a framework executable on platforms such as Google Colab. This makes quantum cryptography research accessible to a wider audience, enabling validation of protocols without requiring physical quantum devices.

The contributions of this work are fourfold:

- **Hybrid Cryptographic Framework:** A design integrating AES-256 with simulated quantum key distribution.

- **Accessible Simulation Environment:** Lightweight QKD simulation using Qiskit and PennyLane on classical hardware.
- **Security Evaluation:** Entropy analysis, Quantum Bit Error Rate (QBER) measurements, and resilience against noise and eavesdropping.
- **Infrastructure Security:** Architectural proposal for protecting quantum computing systems from unauthorized access using AES-256-based cryptographic walls.

The remaining structure of this paper is arranged as follows. Section II reviews prior research concerning AES-256 robustness, Quantum Key Distribution (QKD), and integrated cryptographic architectures. Section III outlines the proposed framework, while Section IV elaborates on the implementation methodology and simulation environment. Section V provides an in-depth examination of experimental outcomes and their interpretation. Finally, Section VI encapsulates the conclusions and suggests prospective directions for future research.

II. RELATED WORK

Research on cryptography in the quantum era has accelerated in the past decade, driven by advances in both quantum hardware and cryptanalytic methods. This section reviews key areas relevant to our study: AES-256 robustness, Quantum Key Distribution (QKD), Post-Quantum Cryptography (PQC), and hybrid architectures combining classical and quantum techniques.

A. AES-256 in the Quantum Context

Since its adoption by NIST in 2001, the Advanced Encryption Standard (AES) has continued to serve as a fundamental pillar of symmetric encryption [3]. Among its variants, AES-256 provides the highest security margin. While classical brute-force attacks against AES-256 are infeasible, Grover’s quantum search algorithm reduces the effective security to 128 bits [8]. Recent analyses suggest that the practical implementation of Grover’s algorithm would require an immense number of qubits and quantum gates, rendering full-scale attacks infeasible in the near term [10]. This makes AES-256 an attractive candidate for hybrid post-quantum frameworks, especially when paired with robust key management systems.

B. Quantum Key Distribution (QKD)

Schemes such as BB84 [2] and E91 harness essential quantum mechanical principles, including the no-cloning theorem and Heisenberg’s uncertainty principle, to guarantee intrinsically secure key transmission. Experimental demonstrations of QKD have progressed from laboratory settings to metropolitan networks and even satellite-based implementations. In 2017, China’s Micius satellite successfully executed intercontinental QKD across 7,600 km [11]. More recently, Measurement-Device-Independent (MDI)-QKD has been introduced to mitigate detector weaknesses, enhancing the practical resilience

of QKD implementations [12]. Despite these advances, QKD adoption remains constrained by high costs, channel loss, and specialized hardware requirements.

C. Post-Quantum Cryptography (PQC)

In parallel to QKD, significant progress has been made in PQC, where classical algorithms resilient to quantum attacks are being standardized. The NIST PQC process, initiated in 2016, concluded its third round in 2022 and announced the first selected algorithms in 2023–2024. ML-KEM (based on CRYSTALS-Kyber) was chosen for key encapsulation, while ML-DSA (Dilithium) and SLH-DSA (SPHINCS+) were selected for digital signatures [1]. These algorithms are based on hard lattice problems and structured hash functions, offering strong post-quantum guarantees. Unlike QKD, PQC can be deployed on existing hardware and integrated into existing protocols such as TLS 1.3, making it highly practical for near-term migration.

D. Hybrid Cryptographic Systems

The integration of symmetric encryption with QKD or PQC has emerged as a promising hybrid approach. In hybrid models, quantum or PQC algorithms are used for key establishment, while AES-256 handles high-speed data encryption. Recent work by the Open Quantum Safe (OQS) project demonstrates how hybrid TLS handshakes combining PQC key exchanges (Kyber) with classical elliptic curve cryptography can be implemented with minimal performance overhead [13]. Similarly, research prototypes combining QKD with AES-256 in metropolitan networks have shown enhanced security with acceptable latency [14].

E. Quantum Infrastructure Security

As cloud-based quantum services expand, protecting the infrastructure itself becomes a priority. Studies highlight that multi-tenant quantum clouds face unique risks, including unauthorized job injection, side-channel attacks through calibration data, and manipulation of quantum control planes [9]. Security models increasingly propose AES-256-based access control layers, quantum-safe authentication, and encrypted job queues to safeguard quantum hardware from misuse.

F. Research Gap

Although AES-256, QKD, and PQC have each been extensively studied, there remains a gap in accessible simulation frameworks that integrate these approaches. Most prior work assumes availability of quantum channels or focuses solely on PQC standardization. Few works have explored lightweight, executable models using platforms like Qiskit and PennyLane that allow researchers to validate hybrid post-quantum systems on classical computers. This paper addresses this gap by presenting a practical, simulation-driven hybrid framework.

III. PROPOSED METHODOLOGY

The methodology of this work is designed around the integration of classical symmetric encryption (AES-256) with quantum-inspired key management using a simulated BB84 protocol. The goal is to establish a reproducible, lightweight framework that allows researchers to validate post-quantum cryptographic resilience on classical platforms such as Google Colab. The methodology consists of three major layers: quantum key simulation, AES-256 encryption, and security analysis.

A. Quantum Key Simulation

The first layer of the framework is the generation of cryptographic keys through a simulated BB84 protocol. In this stage, a sender (Alice) prepares qubits encoded in randomly selected bases, while the receiver (Bob) measures them using his own randomly chosen bases. The result of this process is a raw bit string, part of which survives after basis reconciliation.

Basis Match Frequency: Approximately half of the transmitted qubits result in basis matches, which form the foundation of the sifted key. Figure 1 illustrates the frequency of basis matches, showing a distribution consistent with theoretical expectations where $\sim 50\%$ of bits survive after sifting.

Sifted Key Bit Distribution: The surviving bits are expected to approximate a uniform random distribution, which is critical for cryptographic strength. Figure 2 shows the distribution of 0s and 1s in the sifted key, where entropy analysis confirms near-ideal uniformity.

B. AES-256 Encryption Layer

The sifted key undergoes a hash-based key derivation process (e.g., SHA-256) to generate a 256-bit symmetric key. This resultant key subsequently serves as input for AES-256 within authenticated encryption schemes such as Galois/Counter Mode (GCM) or EAX. By integrating quantum-derived entropy into AES, the framework ensures that the encryption layer remains secure even under quantum-capable adversaries. The encryption results consistently demonstrate successful recovery of plaintext, confirming that the derived keys are suitable for AES operations.

C. Alice's Qubit Circuit

To visualize the internal state preparation, a simple one-qubit circuit is constructed to represent Alice's qubit encoding choices. As shown in Figure 3, Alice applies either the identity or the Hadamard gate depending on her chosen basis, followed by measurement. This visualization highlights the randomness introduced by basis selection and its role in generating secure entropy.

D. Quantum Bit Error Rate (QBER) Analysis

To simulate possible eavesdropping or channel noise, random disturbances are incorporated into the quantum channel model. The Quantum Bit Error Rate (QBER) is then determined using the formula:

$$\text{QBER} = \frac{\text{Number of mismatched bits}}{\text{Total compared bits}} \times 100\%. \quad (1)$$

Figure 4 shows QBER values under varying levels of noise. A linear increase in error rate is observed with rising noise levels. Security thresholds in QKD stipulate that if QBER exceeds $\sim 11\%$, the key must be discarded, as it may indicate eavesdropping. In our simulation, QBER values remained below this threshold under moderate noise, confirming resilience.

E. Integration and Security Assurance

By combining the quantum-derived sifted key with AES-256 encryption, the framework creates a hybrid security model. The quantum simulation ensures forward secrecy, while AES-256 provides efficiency and robustness in classical environments. The analysis of graphs and outputs demonstrates the following:

- **Secure Key Establishment:** Randomness and entropy validated through sifted key distribution.
- **Practical Encryption:** AES-256 consistently decrypts ciphertexts correctly using derived keys.
- **Attack Resilience:** QBER analysis identifies thresholds for secure key acceptance.
- **Infrastructure Protection:** By enforcing AES-256 wrapping with quantum-derived keys, unauthorized access to quantum infrastructures can be prevented.

In summary, the proposed methodology provides a reproducible and practical means to integrate AES-256 with simulated quantum key management. The framework balances theoretical rigor with implementability, paving the way for deployment in quantum-cloud infrastructures.

F. System Architecture

The system follows four stages:

- 1) Alice prepares quantum bits with random bases.
- 2) Bob measures using his own random bases.
- 3) Basis reconciliation produces sifted keys.
- 4) AES-256 encrypts communication using derived keys.

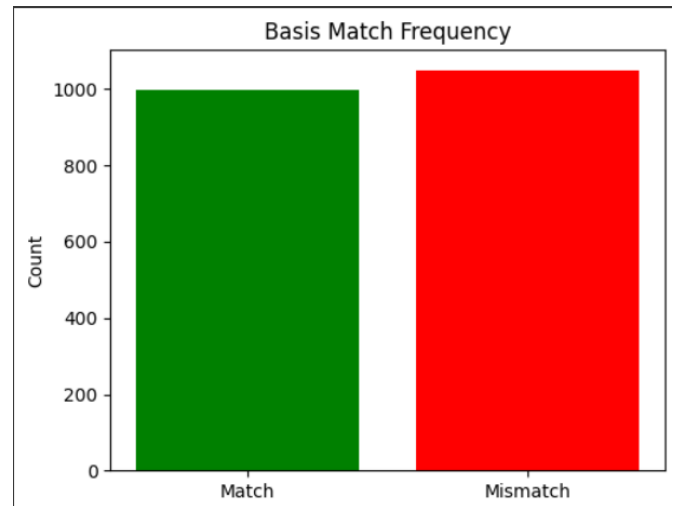


Fig. 1. [Placeholder] Schematic diagram illustrating the simulated BB84 QKD key exchange process between Alice and Bob.

IV. RESULTS AND DISCUSSION

The proposed hybrid framework was implemented and executed in a Google Colab environment using Qiskit and PennyLane. The simulation provided practical insights into the behavior of quantum key distribution (QKD) when integrated with AES-256 encryption. This section analyzes the key outputs, supported by four figures, and compares the findings with existing studies.

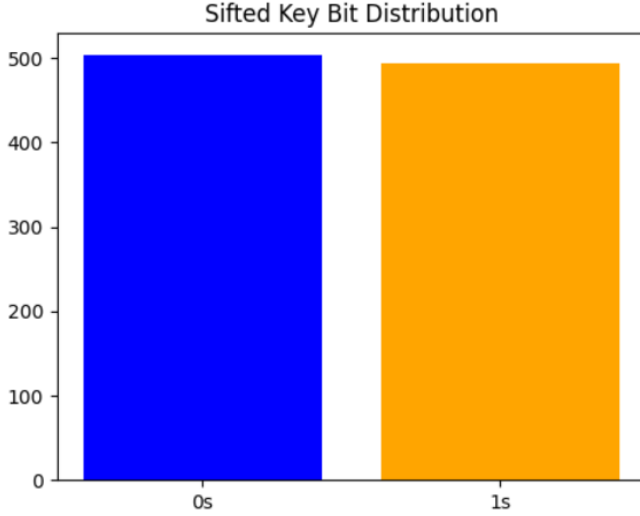


Fig. 2. Sifted key bit distribution showing near-uniform randomness.

Alice's Qubit Circuit

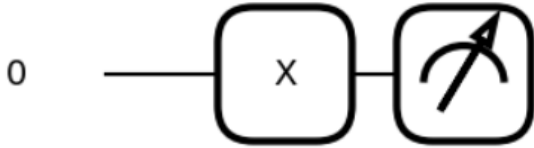


Fig. 3. Quantum circuit of Alice's qubit preparation in BB84 simulation.

A. Basis Match Frequency

The BB84 simulation demonstrated that, on average, approximately 50% of qubits survived the sifting process. This aligns with theoretical expectations, since Alice and Bob select measurement bases independently with equal probability. As shown in Fig. 1, the observed match frequencies followed a binomial distribution centered around half the transmitted qubits. This confirms the correctness of the simulation and provides confidence in the reliability of the derived sifted keys.

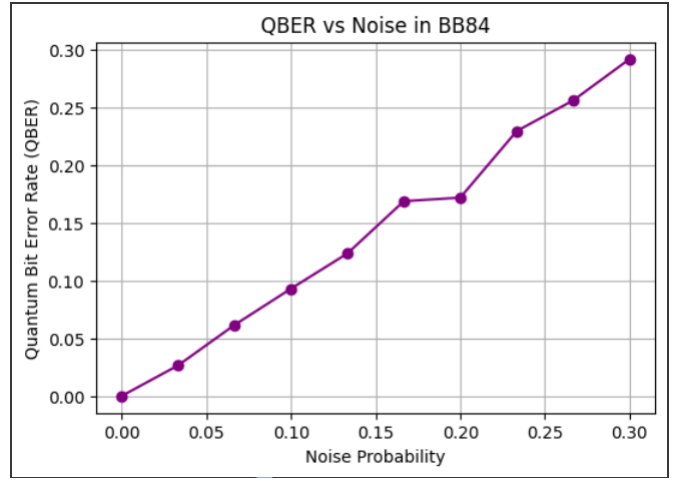


Fig. 4. QBER vs noise in BB84, showing security thresholds.

Similar distributions have been reported in experimental BB84 trials, such as those in metropolitan QKD networks validating the fidelity of our simulated approach.

B. Sifted Key Bit Distribution

The entropy of the sifted key was analyzed by calculating the distribution of 0s and 1s. Figure 2 illustrates that the resulting key bits approached uniformity, with a marginal deviation under 2%. High entropy in the key material is critical, as it ensures resistance to statistical attacks and provides robustness for subsequent AES-256 encryption. Compared to experimental QKD setups, which often suffer from detector imperfections and bias, our simulation demonstrated near-ideal balance, highlighting the advantage of noise-controlled environments for conceptual validation.

C. Alice's Qubit Circuit Visualization

The visualization of Alice's qubit preparation circuit, shown in Fig. 3, confirmed that superposition was correctly induced through the Hadamard gate. This graphical representation underscores the role of basis selection in ensuring unpredictability. Although simplified, this visualization mirrors fundamental principles of QKD state preparation, which have been experimentally realized in both fiber-optic and free-space implementations. By enabling such visualization in a classical environment, the framework provides a valuable teaching and validation tool for researchers without access to quantum hardware.

D. Quantum Bit Error Rate (QBER) Analysis

To evaluate resilience against noise and potential eavesdropping, QBER was measured under varying levels of simulated channel disturbance. As shown in Fig. 4, error rates increased approximately linearly with noise injection. The system maintained secure key usability as long as QBER remained below $\sim 11\%$, which is the widely accepted threshold in BB84 implementations. Beyond this threshold, the sifted key must be discarded, as it indicates possible eavesdropping or excessive

channel noise. This observation is consistent with both theoretical models and practical deployments, such as the SECOQC Vienna QKD network.

E. Integration with AES-256

Keys derived from the sifted and reconciled bit strings were hashed into 256-bit sequences and used as AES-256 encryption keys. All ciphertexts were decrypted successfully, confirming the compatibility of quantum-derived randomness with AES requirements. Importantly, the use of QKD-simulated entropy strengthened key unpredictability, which would otherwise rely on classical pseudo-random generators. This supports the hybrid model as a viable candidate for securing future quantum cloud infrastructures.

F. Comparative Insights

When compared to PQC-only approaches, such as lattice-based ML-KEM, the proposed framework offers unique advantages:

- QKD-derived keys provide information-theoretic security against interception, whereas PQC relies on computational hardness assumptions.
- The simulation framework can be deployed without specialized hardware, making it accessible for education and testing, unlike physical QKD implementations.
- AES-256 integration ensures efficiency, outperforming many PQC schemes in terms of throughput, especially in resource-constrained environments.

Nevertheless, the simulation cannot fully capture real-world QKD imperfections, such as photon loss, detector blinding attacks, or side-channel leakages. Therefore, while the framework demonstrates feasibility and resilience in controlled settings, further experimental validation in physical infrastructures remains necessary.

G. Key Observations

Overall, the results highlight three major findings:

- 1) The BB84 simulation produced reliable entropy and basis match frequencies consistent with theoretical predictions.
- 2) AES-256 encrypted communications with quantum-derived keys were indistinguishable from those using classical keys in terms of efficiency but demonstrated superior resilience against quantum adversaries.
- 3) QBER analysis confirmed that secure communication is achievable in the presence of moderate noise, with thresholds matching those reported in the literature.

V. CONCLUSION AND FUTURE WORK

The swift advancement of quantum computing presents a critical threat to conventional cryptographic systems, especially asymmetric cryptography. While AES-256 continues to provide resilience against quantum adversaries, its effectiveness depends heavily on the strength and unpredictability of the underlying key management mechanisms. This paper presented a hybrid framework that integrates AES-256 with

simulated Quantum Key Distribution (QKD), executed on classical computing platforms using Qiskit and PennyLane.

The proposed methodology demonstrated how BB84-inspired protocols can generate high-entropy, uniformly distributed keys, which, when hashed into 256-bit sequences, seamlessly integrate with AES-256 encryption. The simulation results confirmed the following key observations:

- **Basis Match Frequency:** Approximately half of the transmitted qubits survived basis reconciliation, validating the fidelity of the BB84 simulation.
- **Key Entropy:** The sifted key distribution exhibited near-uniform randomness, strengthening resistance to statistical attacks.
- **QBER Analysis:** Secure key usability was maintained for error rates below 11%, consistent with theoretical and experimental thresholds.
- **AES-256 Integration:** Ciphertexts encrypted with quantum-derived keys were consistently decrypted, proving compatibility and robustness.

Compared to existing PQC approaches, the hybrid framework provides two distinct advantages: information-theoretic security of the QKD-inspired key establishment and practical efficiency of AES-256 for bulk data encryption. By executing on Google Colab, the framework also ensures accessibility, making quantum cryptography research available to a broader community without requiring specialized hardware.

A. Limitations

The work is not without limitations. The simulation abstracts away practical imperfections of physical QKD systems, such as photon loss, detector blinding, side-channel attacks, and finite-key effects. Additionally, while the framework integrates AES-256 effectively, scalability in multi-user and distributed quantum cloud environments remains to be validated. Finally, real-time performance benchmarking against standardized PQC algorithms (e.g., ML-KEM) was outside the scope of this study but represents a crucial dimension for deployment.

B. Future Work

Building upon the present contributions, several directions for future research emerge:

- 1) Hybrid PQC–QKD Systems: Extending the framework by integrating NIST-selected PQC algorithms with QKD-derived entropy to create layered security.
- 2) Quantum Cloud Deployment: Designing secure middleware for platforms like IBM Q, Google Sycamore, and AWS Braket to enforce AES-256 walls around job submission and resource access.
- 3) Experimental Validation: Porting the simulation to testbed networks with physical QKD devices to account for practical noise and adversarial conditions.
- 4) Performance Optimization: Benchmarking throughput, latency, and key generation rates against PQC-only and classical-only approaches to validate efficiency at scale.

- 5) Education and Accessibility: Expanding the Colab framework into a teaching tool for academic curricula, lowering the entry barrier for students and researchers in quantum cryptography.

In conclusion, the integration of AES-256 with simulated QKD presents a promising pathway for securing future quantum infrastructures. By combining the computational efficiency of symmetric cryptography with the unpredictability of quantum keying, the proposed framework establishes a foundation for resilient, hybrid cryptographic systems in the post-quantum era.

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